

God so loved the world

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Introduction

I live in the western world, or in the United States, more specifically. Our culture is widely known throughout the world.

Some of the most common messages in this culture include:

“To thine own self be true.” - William Shakespeare, Hamlet

“All our dreams can come true...” - Walt Disney

“You gotta fight for your right...” - The Beastie Boys

Among your Rights “are Life, Liberty and the pursuit of Happiness.”
- The Declaration of Independence

“We must oppose the spread of hate...” - The Human Rights Organization

“Join the Movement to fight for Freedom, Liberation and Justice...” - Black Lives Matter

“Be who you are...” - The Pride Foundation

These are messages that billions get behind. This book is about such messaging from our culture, and also how our culture is different from the culture of heaven.

1. Happiness, individualism, and pride

Our culture lifts up human happiness, individualism, and pride. One can be made happy by achieving one's dreams. Our culture sees love for others and being loved by others as the center of happiness. The individual and their choices are preeminent. Everyone is beautiful just as they are. That which comes naturally to them is good.

According to the Bible, the culture of heaven has different messaging:

It's not about you. It's about God.

"You shall love the Lord your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your might." Deuteronomy 6:5

About two thirds of America believes in God, and about two thirds believes in heaven, while a bit less than half now see the Bible as inspired by God. According to Jesus' words uttered directly after the world's most popular Bible verse, John 3:16, He said that people don't like God's words because they are light and people don't like to come into the light (John 3:19-21).

Jesus of Nazareth is nothing if not countercultural. His words ran counter to the Jewish culture and traditions of His time, prompting His execution. Jesus' recorded words in the Bible also run counter to the culture and the traditions of our time, even to the majority of the culture and traditions of the individuals identifying with the religious right and the religious liberals in the United States.

"It's not about you," is the message of heaven.

It's not about your happiness. When you seek your own happiness, you invite misery.

Instead, God is at the center of everything, rather than you. It's about His glory. It's about lifting up His majesty and beauty and magnificence, bright shining as the sun. God is preeminent and exalted above all.

Further, only the blessing of God in your life can truly make you happy. You are blessed by Him on His terms. Fortunately, He is good to all. (See my book [God is good](#) for more on this.)

Heaven speaks the message, "it's about God."

When Jesus was asked what was the greatest commandment, He repeated Deuteronomy 6:5: “You shall love the Lord your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your might.”

You are to love God on His terms – with everything you are and everything you have. This is worship.

In God’s view, love isn’t a feeling. It speaks, and it takes action.

Loving God like this is a lifestyle. It’s all consuming. It requires everything of you. It is steadfast.

It requires that you trust God, as revealed by His recorded words to you.

It requires that you love God first, above any man or woman or child.

We also fear who or what we love most; we fear losing and displeasing anyone or anything which we have exulted. It turns out that most of our choices are motivated by the fear of people, because we fear people above God, and because we love people more than we love God.

God is good. He’s worthy of our trust. God is worthy of being called Lord and treated as such. He is worthy of the steadfast love that He requires of us.

On our own, we have doubted God though. We are sinful, and we are separated from God. We are not right. We are dead spiritually, unable to see truth or communicate with God. We are subject to physical death. We cannot remain happy. The love of the world cannot make us happy. It’s fleeting like vapor.

This message from heaven is very different from the message of our culture.

Many don’t like this message. It’s not convenient. It’s not comfortable. It’s not popular.

This doesn’t make it untrue.

2. Equity, human rights, and diversity

Our culture lifts up equity, human rights, and diversity. Western culture has taken leadership in decades gone by to free slaves and to advance women's rights, black rights, rights for the disabled, and now, more recently, for LGBT rights. Recently in the United States, certain organizations have come to the forefront: the Human Rights Organization, Black Lives Matter, and the Pride Foundation. Diversity is becoming increasingly valued in the western culture, especially in the last few years. Tolerance has become highly valued.

According to the Bible, the culture of heaven has related, albeit different messaging: 'Then God said, "Let us make man in our image, after our likeness...male and female he created them. And God blessed them..."' Genesis 1:26-28a

"...in Christ Jesus you are all sons of God, through faith. For as many of you as were baptized into Christ have put on Christ. There is neither Jew nor Greek, there is neither slave nor free, there is no male and female, for you are all one in Christ Jesus. And if you are Christ's, then you are Abraham's offspring, heirs according to the promise." Galatians 3:26-29

Equity and human rights. Rather than Western culture having been responsible for the freedom of slaves and human rights, it's argued by many that it's the Christian principles affecting Western culture that were responsible for the increase in freedoms since 1834, when the UK passed the Slavery Abolition Act.¹ Significant credit for the Slavery Abolition Act goes to William Wilberforce, who was responsible for steering anti-trade legislation through the British parliament. His abolitionism has been attributed to his evangelical Christianity, to which he was converted in 1784-85. Another early advocate against slavery and for women's rights was the co-founder of the Salvation Army, Catherine Booth (1829-1890). And, of course, the world will not forget the contributions and the boldness of Dr. Martin Luther King, Jr. (1929-1968), an outspoken man of faith in Jesus Christ.

The Christian principles associated with human dignity and equality are embodied in part in the two verses cited above, the first taken from the Old Testament and the second from the New Testament. In Christian theology, all people have great value because they were created in God's image and likeness (Genesis 1:26), just a little

¹ I'm sure it can also be argued that many self-proclaimed Christians have been responsible for many abuses of freedom. To this I would reply that it is for Christ to decide who truly are His followers, and He has said, "... no good tree bears bad fruit, nor again does a bad tree bear good fruit, for each tree is known by its own fruit" (Luke 6:43-44) and "Not everyone who says to me, 'Lord, Lord,' will enter the kingdom of heaven, but the one who does the will of my Father who is in heaven" (Matthew 7:21).

lower than God Himself (Psalm 8:5). To be made in God's image and likeness means that we have the potential to take on God's own characteristics and nature, or as the Apostle Peter wrote, to "become partakers of the divine nature" (2 Peter 1:4). The man Jesus of Nazareth was the exact imprint of God's nature (Hebrews 1:3), and all Christ followers are "predestined to be conformed to" His image (Romans 8:29). There is complete equality among those who are in Christ Jesus, having been baptized into Him and "put on" Christ (Galatians 3:26-27). They are all children of God, having great worth, just as the Jews were identified as such in the Old Testament. All people are image bearers and have the choice to become children of God through becoming committed disciples of Jesus Christ. Disciples do not treat others as lesser than.²

Diversity. God loves the diversity of the people He has made. He called His creation good (Genesis 1:31). All men and women were made in His image and likeness, just a little lower than Himself. His children are His glory (1 Corinthians 11:7). Thus, having been made in the image and likeness of our glorious God, all human life is sacred. Further, though all have sinned, it is not God's will that anyone be destroyed, but instead that everyone would come to repentance (2 Peter 3:9), so that they could become His children (John 1:13) and receive all of the goodness that He desires to pour out on them (Ephesians 2:6-7).

While God loves men and women of every race, nation, age, disability, and socioeconomic status, He does not love sin, which is active rebellion against Him or passive indifference to Him. God is holy, and He made His children to be holy, so we are not ok just as we are, being sons of Adam and daughters of Eve. Like Adam and Eve, we have bowed our knee to sin and the devil, who then blinded our minds to truth (2 Corinthians 4:4). We cannot edit what God considers to be sin because we are now inclined toward it, for it is He who authored all physical and spiritual laws when He created all that was good. To be restored to our rightful place as God's children, repentance; faith in Jesus Christ; and a commitment to follow Christ, walking as He walked, is necessary. To walk as Christ walked, we must come to think as Christ thinks; this is work of repentance, which is a change of mind and purpose brought about by ever reorienting ourselves toward God. God does not tolerate sin. Instead, God frees us from sin through the person and the power of Jesus Christ.

While God is full of grace, that grace trains us to "renounce worldly passions, and to live self-controlled, upright, and godly lives in the present age, waiting for... the appearing

² I'm sure many self-proclaimed Christians have abused others in areas related to equity and diversity. With regard to this, see the first footnote. Additionally, everyone (or nearly everyone) deserves to be treated with kindness and respect. Note that Jesus Christ was gracious with the masses, but He did not always respectfully treat those who defied God's law, especially the Pharisees and those associated with them (e.g., Matthew 23:23, John 2:15). Jesus Christ used rebuke to point out that which was right.

of... Jesus Christ, who gave himself for us to redeem us from all lawlessness and to purify for himself a people for his own possession who are zealous for good works” (Titus 2:11-14). While Christ came to set us at liberty, this is not a liberty to do as we please, but rather a liberty to choose to do what pleases God. We are to choose to be who God made us to be. In repentance, we, like Jesus, are to choose to align our will with the will of our Father (John 6:38).

This means the culture of heaven differs significantly from Western culture.

Choosing our own way apart from God (Romans 1:21), we’ll never truly sense our value. On our own, there will not be equality. On our own, diversity will not be valued; self-interest is too strong. On your own, you won’t be included in God’s family; we have all bowed our knee to the opposition. On your own, things will not be right. On our own, things cannot be made right.

3. Pluralism, reason, and life

Our culture lifts up pluralism, reason, and life.

Pluralism as a way of thinking emerged with the ancient Greeks. Pluralism was effectively embraced within the constitutional framework of the United States, and pluralistic thinking has been on the rise in the West ever since the awareness of the rest of the world has been on the increase due to the proliferation of means of global communication and travel. It's been embraced especially well by many public personalities of our day.

Reason. The glorification of man's reason in the West has been on the increase since the truthfulness of the Bible has come under serious attack. This started in the mid-1600s, or perhaps earlier in the Reformation (the 1500s). Reason holds up the value of the five senses, and it holds up the scientific method as the most valuable way of understanding the natural world. Reason is embraced as the highest form of truth by many groups, among them being secular humanists, atheists, and satanists. When reason is valued along with pluralism, it's called being open-minded.

Life. In all times, people have pursued the things that bring them enjoyment of life in the moment. King Solomon wrote, "... a man hath no better thing under the sun, than to eat, drink, and be merry..." (Ecclesiastes 8:15). The Apostle John summarized such pursuit as "the desires of the flesh and the desires of the eyes and the pride of life" (1 John 2:16).

According to the Bible, the culture of heaven has different messaging than our culture: 'Jesus said to [Thomas], "I am the way, and the truth, and the life. No one comes to the Father except through me." ' John 14:6

The way. Jesus of Nazareth claimed to be the only way to salvation, which is necessary for reasons discussed in the last chapter. His disciples ran with this teaching. For example, after Jesus' resurrection, the Apostle Peter told the Jewish Council, "...there is salvation in no one else, for there is no other name under heaven given among men by which we must be saved" (Acts 4:12).

This message runs in direct opposition to pluralism. It's a narrow view, consistent with what Jesus preached:

"Enter by the narrow gate. For the gate is wide and the way is easy that leads to destruction, and those who enter by it are many. For the gate is narrow and the way is hard that leads to life, and those who find it are few" (Matthew 7:13-14).

The path of thinking like and following in Jesus' steps is narrow. It's also a difficult path because it requires one to die to their old nature (John 12:24-25) and to face opposition from others because obedience to Christ requires going against one's culture (Matthew 5:10-12, 10:34-39). Many who call themselves Christians do not want to take this path.

The truth. As discussed in the last chapter, our minds have been blinded by sin and its author (2 Corinthians 4:4), so we cannot know truth through reason. Jesus of Nazareth claimed to be Truth itself. He said to the man who would condemn Him to death, "For this purpose I was born and for this purpose I have come into the world – to bear witness to the truth. Everyone who is of the truth listens to my voice" (John 18:37). He was primarily known as one whose teaching astonished, for He taught as "one who had authority, and not as their scribes." For especially important truths to be taught, He preceded them with, "Truly, Truly, I say to you." The Apostle John recorded 25 instances of this in His gospel.

The life. Jesus of Nazareth claimed to be life itself, both life now and life eternal (see also John 3:16 and 10:10). His resurrection was witnessed by many and is true. Following resurrection, He ascended into heaven to sit at God's right hand, having authority over all things. The Bible teaches that Jesus Christ quickens (gives life to) the spirit, mind and body of His committed disciples. The spirit is the part of the body connected to God, and it is by nature (of our sin) disconnected from God. "But he who is joined to the Lord [Jesus] becomes one spirit with him" (1 Corinthians 6:10). By way of the Holy Spirit, Christ comes to live in committed believers, cooperating with them to transform them by the renewal of their mind (Romans 12:2), causing them to think like He thinks (1 Corinthians 2:16). The Spirit of Jesus Christ comes to dwell in believers, giving life also to their bodies (Romans 8:11). Christ lives and operates in our world now through His committed disciples.

This message from heaven is very different from the message of our culture.

Following our own way (that does not align with Jesus Christ's way) leads to feeling lost, confused, and disappointed. It leads to a sense of things not being right. It leads to bondage and to death.

4. Morality, benevolence, and inclusion

Our culture prides its common morality, including benevolence and inclusion. We believe we are responsible for our actions. We believe it is generally wrong to kill, to cause pain, to deceive, and to cheat. We generally believe it is right to help one's family. Many believe in dividing resources fairly. Many value the principle of paying it forward, or giving back. Some believe that nobility obligates them to give back (*noblesse oblige*). Some believe they should leave things better than they found them. Some see themselves as members of a global community, desiring to leave the world better than they found it. In our common belief that we should treat others and we would like to be treated, our culture prizes inclusion despite age, gender, sexual orientation, race, ethnicity, national origin, education, religion, creed, beliefs, marital status, experiences, disability, neurodiversity, or socioeconomic status. We believe we should consider the perspective of others. We mean well and we see ourselves as good.

According to the Bible, the culture of heaven has different messaging than our culture: "We have all become like one who is unclean, and all our righteous deeds are like a polluted garment. " Isaiah 64:6a

"And Jesus said to [a rich young man], "Why do you call me good? No one is good except God alone." Mark 10:18

Morality. We believe we are good, but the God who made us and the world does not see it that way. We were made for a close relationship with the God who made us in His image and likeness, yet we choose to doubt His goodness and good intent. Or we may doubt His existence altogether. We were made to worship God, and we have given our worship to other people and things that He made. Further, looking at our world, we do not generally see or experience benevolence or grace from people. Most are self-absorbed. Most do not keep what we see as common morality. In the end, our attitude includes passive indifference toward God and our actions include active rebellion against His divine law recorded in the Bible. This is sin. It separates us from our righteous God. Our trespasses against divine law subject us to condemnation, bondage, and death. This death is both spiritual (cutoff from communication with God) and physical.

There's nothing we can do about it.

Benevolence. "But God, being rich in mercy, because of the great love with which he loved us, even when we were dead in our trespasses, made us alive together with Christ—by grace you have been saved—" Ephesians 2:4-5

There is good news. The God who created you loves you and is rich in mercy. He has made a way through the gift of His Son, Jesus Christ, to free you and bring you from death to life. Jesus Christ came into our world to restore you to an intimate relationship with God, proclaiming the kingdom of heaven was at hand.

Inclusion. By deciding to follow God's plan for you in Christ, you are able to join yourself to the kingdom and culture of heaven as a son or daughter of God! Jesus brought the rule of God back into the world – and with it freedom from sin, bondage, sickness and death. His ministry demonstrated that freedom from the natural consequences of our sin. That ministry was handed over to committed disciples of Christ, and it continues to this day.

God so loved the world, not because of who we are, but because of whose we are – His.

God loves you — no matter who you are, no matter what your past. God loves you so much that He gave His one and only begotten Son for you. The Bible tells us that "...whoever believes in him shall not perish but have eternal life" (John 3:16 NIV). Jesus laid down His life and rose again so that we could spend eternity with Him in heaven and experience His absolute best on earth.

If you would like to receive Jesus into your life, say the following prayer out loud and mean it from your heart.

Heavenly Father, I come to You admitting that I am a sinner. Right now, I choose to turn away from sin, and I ask You to cleanse me of all unrighteousness. I believe that Your Son, Jesus, died on the cross to take away my sins. I also believe that He rose again from the dead so that I would be forgiven of my sins and made righteous through faith in Him. I call upon the name of Jesus Christ to be the Savior and Lord of my life. Jesus, I choose to follow You and ask that You fill me with the power of the Holy Spirit. I declare that right now I am a child of God. I am free from sin and full of the righteousness of God. I am saved in Jesus' name. Amen. (Text and prayer by HC)

For next steps, please contact me at teams.church@gmail.com or [through Instagram chat](#). Please also read through [Word Prompts for Salvation and Discipleship](#) in order to know more about belief and commitment to Jesus Christ as one of His disciples. I'm happy to discuss it with you.